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From the editor-in-chief

Almost 64 years after Independence, India has changed beyond recognition but in social terms, large parts of it remain in a medieval time warp, from child marriage to khaps that order killings of young couples for violating caste customs. Undoubtedly, India has had caste entrenched in its social fabric for millennia but democratic politics in independent India, which should have been an agent of progressive change, has done quite the opposite. In spite of all the fine work done by Mahatma Gandhi and the founding fathers of our Constitution to get rid of the curse of caste in India, it has steadily been undone by our self serving politicians. It all started in recent times when prime minister V.P. Singh reopened the Mandal issue in 1990 as official government policy.

No reasonable person disputes the need for the state to help the economically downtrodden but when this is based on caste, it strengthens all the regressive forces in society. Since then caste politics has got an official sanction in our electoral arithmetic. It is amply demonstrated by politicians like Mayawati, Lalu Prasad Yadav and Mulayam Singh Yadav, and, in varying degrees, by every political party who have exploited caste to grab power. Last week, by agreeing to add caste to the census exercise for the first time, the Manmohan Singh Government for political expediency has lit the fuse of a huge caste time-bomb for which generations will suffer. The Constitution places special emphasis on outlawing caste discrimination. Besides, it is a humiliating rejection of the huge strides India has taken in economic growth and in its efforts for creating a modern society.

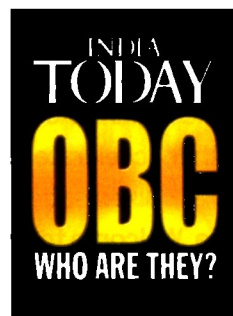
Admittedly, the country is still ridden by caste hierarchies, as the matrimonial columns prove, but to enumerate caste in a census is to legitimise caste politics and all the social ills it brings. It makes a mockery of merit, opportunity and social equality. By authorising a caste-based census, the Centre is setting the stage for increased demands for reservations and the creation of dangerous social divides. It is a shameful betrayal of the Constitution for the sake of political survival. It is a great irony that this should happen under the watch of a man like Prime Minister Manmohan Singh who is credited with the birth of a liberal India.

India's caste and sub-caste matrix was a complex layer of identity and power where one's birth defined social status, education, marriage, jobs and future prospects. Now, in one stroke, it's back, concealed in the garb of social justice and social science. It is an open invitation with an official seal for the political bigots to further exploit the tyranny of caste politics.

Our cover package is a hard, in-depth look at the Centre's decision and an analysis of the divisive reach of caste in national life. We look at how India is still steeped in caste politics, the historical imperative, the reach of caste in politics, employment, education and the potential dangers that a caste-based census poses.

The 14th prime minister of India would do well to heed the words of the first one, Jawaharlal Nehru: "A caste-ridden society is not properly secular. When a person's beliefs become petrified in caste divisions, they affect the social structure of the state and prevent us from realising the idea of equality which we claim to place before all else." Alas, today it would be a cry in the wilderness.

(Aroon Purie)



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